First Congregational Church of St. Albans (FCC) is a welcoming community of spiritual seekers, believers, and doubters.

Please know that no *matter who you are or where you are on life's journey, you're welcome here.*

First Congregational Church Vision Statement

To create an open and loving community that encourages a joyous exploration with God.
To work together to care for and nurture the wider community.

First Congregational Church Mission Statement

Our mission as a community resource church is to provide a safe place for spiritual exploration and personal growth. To affirm the value of each person and to meet them where they are.
To connect to the community through personal service, giving, and pastoral care.

Please feel free to contact us:
Administrative Office: Tuesday - Friday 9am-2pm
Church Office Phone Number: 802-524-4555
info@firstcongregationalstalbans.org
Pastor Jessica's Office Hours: Friday 9:30am - Noon
Email: pastorjessica@firstcongregationalstalbans.org
Pastor Jessica takes her Sabbath on Mondays.
For urgent, pastoral matters outside of regular office hours, call Pastor Jessica at 207-632-5544.

Our worship service is broadcast over the local public access channel 1079 on Sundays at 4 PM.

Scripture Reader: Rich Guzman
Acolytes: Mykala Pryor, Ada Sanders, and Kaia Newton

UNITED CHURCH OF CHRIST

First Congregational Church of St. Albans
An open and affirming community.



"We welcome you and serve all through faith."

Worship with us:
March 30, 2025
10 am

Rev. Jessica Moore, Pastor
Bailey Brown, Choir & Music Director
Stephan Conrady, Organist
Stephen McLaughlin, Office Manager
27 Church Street, St. Albans, VT 05478
802-524-4555
www.firstcongregationalstalbans.org

Fourth Sunday of Lent March 30, 2025

We Gather as God's People

Centering Words**:**

Just take this as a warning. Know that there's always a price for not being yourself. — Benilde Little

THE PREPARATION

The beginning of the prelude is a call to enter into the spirit of prayer and community.

Prelude

Welcome and Announcements

Sung Call To Worship *Bless the Lord, My Soul* (Taizé)

Bless the Lord, my soul
and Bless God's Holy name
Bless the Lord, my soul
who leads me into life.

Morning Prayer[1] **(Unison)**

God meets us in the night— before the sun rises, before the wound heals, before there are answers, before there is closure
God meets us in the light— where joy is effervescent, where laughter is contagious, where flowers bloom from cracks in the sidewalk, where people gather around tables.
God meets us in between— at the edge of the water, at the beginning of the wilderness, at the start of something new, on the edge of faith.
And if God meets us in all those places, then surely God meets us everywhere— at the water's edge, at the start of

Welcome to all visitors: We are delighted that you chose to worship with us today and are strengthened by your participation in our service!
If you are new to First Congregational Church of St. Albans, please sign the guest book in the narthex (main entrance of the church).
If you would like more information about our church and its programs or would like to receive our Morning Reflections, and weekly e-newsletter, "From the Manse," please fill out a Welcome Card and place it in the Offering tray (be sure to include your email address).

After the service please join us for fellowship, conversation, coffee, and refreshments.

*Please Stand If You Are Able

[1]A Sanctified Arts

Music, Copyright permissions: CCLI #4799426 and SJMP #14586

Walking the Walk Nugget: This Lent FCC member, Doug Klette will be giving us communication "Nuggets"–practical steps to help us better love our neighbor.

We have looked at the Roadblocks to Effective Communication, Listening Skills that promote accurate understanding for both the speaker and the listener, and action steps one can take to prevent being sucked into a destructive Power Struggle. At this point one might ask, "Why do I have to do all the work? This is simply too TOUCHY FEELY for me. I'm tired of trying to be nice. I'd like to tell them off!

Though, the above, is what we often think, in practice we frequently hold onto our feelings of anger and resentment and never address legitimate issues. We are afraid (it is called STAMP COLLECTING; holding onto grudges and keeping score about how many times the other has hurt you).

It takes an enormous amount of courage to tell someone that their behavior is painful to you. It takes even greater courage to do so without needing to hurt them emotionally! Most people are shocked to learn that ASSERTIVENESS can be an act of love for the sender and the person viewed as the enemy.

There is a formula to help you: (Pretend your neighbor has not returned your mower and your grass really needs to be mowed.)

Destructive approach: "Bill, I don't know who you think you are, but you should have returned my mower a long time ago. Man, you are a selfish Jerk!"

Healthier Respectful Approach: (#1. State The Problem (leaving out cheap shots); #2. Share your Feeling (but not by saying, "You make me feel...."), ; #3. State the "Tangible Effect" of not having the mower (without rubbing it in their face).

Example: "Bill, I'm concerned you haven't returned my lawnmower, and I'm worried, because the grass is really getting long, and it will be harder to cut."

Life is not simple. Bill may not comply. You need not give up. There are more interventions that can be used. For now, give yourself credit for refusing to settle for hating Bill (or your spouse, or child, or boss, or friends you hold in your heart).

something new, after the baptism, and before the call. We are not alone.
God is all around. Let us worship the God of everything.

HYMN*

This Is The Day of New Beginnings NCH 417

PRAYER OF TRANSFORMATION[1] **(Unison)**

If God is a painter,
let us be the brush.
If God is a musician,
let us be the song.
If God is an architect,
let us be the tools.
Let us be the hands. Let us be the builders.
But if God is a shepherd, who never stops seeking,
let us be willing to be found, no matter how lost we feel.
Our God is never far away.
Forgive us for forgetting this good news. Amen.

PAUSE FOR REFLECTION

WORDS OF ASSURANCE

PASSING OF THE PEACE

THE MESSAGE

TIME WITH CHILDREN

ANTHEM *The Holy City* Stephen Adams

SCRIPTURE READING Luke 15:1-7

CONTEMPORARY READING *The Good Shepherd* Sarah Speed

MORNING REFLECTION

UNEXPECTED

HYMN*

God Is My Shepherd (1, 2, 5) NCH 479

THE THANKSGIVING

Sharing Our Joys and Concerns

Choral Call To Prayer

Hear Our Prayer, O Lord D. Welpton

Pastor's Prayer~

Lord's Prayer

Our Father who art in heaven, hallowed be thy name. Thy kingdom come, thy will be done, on earth as it is in heaven. Give us this day our daily bread. And forgive us our trespasses, as we forgive those who trespass against us. And lead us not into temptation, but deliver us from evil. For thine is the kingdom and the power and the glory, forever, Amen

Choral Response To Prayer

Thou wilt keep him in perfect peace, whose mind is stayed on thee. Scottish Psalter, 1615

OFFERTORY

Doxology

Praise God from whom all blessing flow
Praise God all creatures here below;
Praise God above, all heavenly hosts:
Creator, Christ and Holy Ghost. Amen.

Offertory Prayer

THE DEPARTURE

Hymn*

Lord, Dismiss Us with Your Blessing NCH 77

Benediction

Postlude

❖ END OF SERVICE ❖

Announcements:

A Special Note of Gratitude From All of Us At FCC:

★ To everyone who helped clean out the handicap ramp– Thank You for keeping our church clutter-free and accessible!

CVOEO Community Action Need
The Motel Program is ending and there is need for . . .
Tarps and sleeping bags (gently used sleeping bags welcome). Bring to church and CA will come pick them up!

April 3
6:30-8:00PM
Migrant Justice Rapid Response Training in the FCC Sanctuary more details to come.
Please invite your friends but we ask that you do **not** share this event on social media.

April 8
6:30-8:00PM
Misery Loves Company Resistance Social
FCC Fellowship Hall
Bring your favorite snack and nonalcoholic drink and join us for some time to relax, commiserate, vent, laugh, and support one another. Sponsored by Franklin County Vermont Women for Democracy– **ALL are welcome!**

Zoom Bible Study: Companionship on the Road
Wednesdays 7:00-8:00pm
April 2
Luke 19: 1-10
Contact Pastor Jessica for the link

Online Giving:
Wi-Fi:
Fellowship Hall
fellowship123

